Name: **Group:** **Date:**

4 ESO · SEASONS & CELEBRATIONS · ROUTE PRO

Learning Path 2 · Celebrations around the world

✏️ Paper worksheet: do the same activities as on the computer. Write your answers and circle the letter of the right option. Do it without notes the first time.

🎯 My goal

Before you start: think about your last recall or checkpoint. What do you want to get better at in this Learning Path?

1 Recall: Getting started

Type the answers without looking. Some are collocations, some are word formation (the word in CAPITALS changes form).

1. As October ends, the nights start drawing _____.
2. A sudden, short period of very cold weather is a cold _____.
3. Many people suffer from _____ (SEASON) affective disorder in winter.
4. Shops start selling Christmas decorations _____ (ABSURD) early.
5. Halloween has become increasingly _____ (COMMERCE) in Spain.
6. The Castanyada dates _____ to the old harvest and All Saints' celebrations.
7. I'm dying to see the fireworks. → I can hardly _____ the fireworks. (2 words)
8. Autumn is my favourite season, _____ far. (2 letters)

2 C2 vocabulary: ritual, festivity and meaning

Explore the words (hover for a definition and an example), go through the cards and complete the sentences. These are the words that make a C2 answer sound precise rather than general.

English	Meaning	Example
Ritual and observance		
observe (a festival)	to follow the customs of a religious or traditional occasion	Fewer families observe the fast strictly these days.
observance	the practice of following a religious or traditional custom	Religious observance has declined, but the festival survives.
festivities	the activities organised to celebrate something	The festivities go on until dawn.
revelry	noisy, lively celebration, often with drinking and dancing	The night of revelry ends with a fire run.
solemn	serious and formal, without fun or noise	All Saints' Day is a solemn occasion for many families.
jubilant	extremely happy because of a success or celebration	Jubilant crowds filled the square at midnight.

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English	Meaning	Example
pagan	connected with old religions that existed before the main world religions	Many winter customs have pagan origins.
syncretism	the mixing of different religions or traditions into one	Christmas is a textbook case of syncretism.
Collocations and idioms		
steeped in tradition	full of a long history of customs	The town is steeped in tradition.
time-honoured	respected because it has existed for a long time	a time-honoured recipe
deeply rooted	firmly established for a long time, hard to change	The custom is deeply rooted in rural life.
ring in the New Year	to celebrate the start of the year at midnight	We rang in the New Year in the main square.
push the boat out	to spend a lot of money or effort to celebrate	For my grandmother's eightieth we really pushed the boat out.
go all out	to make the greatest possible effort	Our street goes all out for Sant Joan.
a far cry from	very different from	Today's Halloween is a far cry from the Celtic Samhain.
the festive spirit	the happy, generous mood of a celebration	Not everyone is in the festive spirit in December.
Word families (for word formation)		
celebratory	adjective: done to celebrate something	a celebratory dinner
celebrant	noun: the person who leads a ceremony	The celebrant lit the first candle.
traditionalist	noun: someone who wants to keep traditions as they are	Traditionalists complained about the new parade route.
commercialisation	noun: the process of making something mainly about money	the commercialisation of Christmas
ritualistic	adjective: done in exactly the same way every time, like a ritual	a ritualistic exchange of gifts
reverence	noun: deep respect	The candles are lit with reverence.

Words you will hear or read (no need to learn them): liturgical · solstice · equinox · effigy · votive · carnivalesque

Study them: cover the meaning column and define each word in your own words. Then complete the sentences without looking at the table.

Complete the sentences

1. Today's Halloween is a far _____ from the Celtic festival of Samhain.
2. For my parents' anniversary we really pushed the _____ out.
3. The village is _____ in tradition: some customs are centuries old.
4. Some people complain about the _____ (COMMERCIAL) of Christmas.
5. Lighting the candles is done with great _____ (REVERE).
6. Christmas mixes Christian and pagan elements: a clear example of _____.
7. The crowd was _____ when the clock struck twelve. (very happy, starts with j)
8. Fewer families _____ the religious side of the festival nowadays. (follow the customs)
9. They organised a _____ (CELEBRATE) dinner after the parade.

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10. We rang _____ the New Year with fireworks.

3 Reading: Why we light up the darkest days

A C2 Proficiency-style text (Reading and Use of English, Part 5). Read it all once for the writer's argument, then answer. The questions test attitude, implication and reference, not facts you can simply find.

Why we light up the darkest days

It is tempting to treat the festivals of light that cluster around the turn of the year as a happy coincidence: Diwali in the autumn, Hanukkah and Christmas in December, Lunar New Year as winter loosens its grip. Yet coincidence is a lazy explanation for something so persistent. Wherever the nights grow long, people seem compelled to answer the dark with flame, and to do so together.

The anthropologist's answer is that these festivals are, at bottom, acts of collective reassurance. A community that gathers to light lamps is not merely decorating; it is rehearsing, year after year, the conviction that the darkness is temporary. That such rituals outlived the agricultural calendars that gave rise to them is hardly surprising. The fear they address, that things may not get better, has proved rather more durable than the threshing floor.

What is surprising is how readily the meaning of each festival is renegotiated. Hanukkah, a relatively minor date in the religious calendar, acquired its present prominence partly because it falls so close to Christmas. Lunar New Year, once an intensely local affair of village shrines and family altars, now triggers the largest annual migration on the planet. Diwali lamps are as likely to be LED strings bought online as clay diyas shaped by hand. Purists lament each of these shifts, and they are not entirely wrong to do so: something is lost when a ritual becomes a product.

But the lament usually rests on a fiction, namely that there was once an original, uncontaminated version from which everything since has declined. Festivals have always borrowed, absorbed and adapted. The evergreen tree, the Yule log and the midwinter feast were folded into Christmas centuries ago; few of those who now defend a "traditional" Christmas would recognise the one they imagine they are defending. Tradition, in other words, is less a fixed inheritance than a conversation each generation conducts with the last.

None of this makes the festivals less meaningful. If anything, their adaptability is the source of their strength. A ritual that could not survive the move from candle to bulb, or from village to megacity, would long since have been abandoned. The light changes; the gesture endures.

1. In the first paragraph, the writer suggests that calling the festivals a "coincidence" is…
   a) correct, but only for festivals in the northern hemisphere
   b) an explanation that avoids thinking about why they keep happening
   c) a view held mainly by religious people **d)** a common mistake made by historians
2. What does the writer mean by "rehearsing" the conviction that the darkness is temporary?
   a) repeating a belief so that it stays alive in the community **b)** preparing a performance for visitors
   c) practising for an event that has not happened yet
   d) pretending to believe something nobody really believes
3. The reference to "the threshing floor" is used to show that…
   a) agricultural work used to take place at night
   b) the fear behind the festivals has lasted longer than the farming life that created them
   c) farmers were more afraid of the dark than city people **d)** modern festivals still depend on the harvest

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4. How does the writer regard the “purists” in the third paragraph?
   a) They are completely mistaken. **b)** They are the only people who understand the festivals.
   c) They have a point, but their view is only partly right.
   d) They are responsible for the commercial changes.
5. What is the “fiction” mentioned in the fourth paragraph?
   a) the story behind the Hanukkah candles **b)** the belief that Christmas has pagan roots
   c) the claim that festivals are becoming less popular
   d) the idea that each festival once existed in a pure, unchanged form
6. The sentence “few of those who now defend a ‘traditional’ Christmas would recognise the one they imagine they are defending” is an example of…
   a) a personal anecdote **b)** a statistic **c)** a counter-argument the writer accepts **d)** irony
7. Which statement best sums up the writer’s overall argument?
   a) Modern technology has spoiled traditional celebrations.
   b) Every culture has invented the same festival independently.
   c) Festivals survive precisely because they keep changing.
   d) Festivals of light are losing their original meaning.
8. “The light changes; the gesture endures.” Here “the gesture” refers to…
   a) the religious meaning of each festival **b)** the way people greet each other at festivals
   c) the use of clay lamps **d)** the shared act of answering darkness with light

4 Summary and response (C2 Proficiency writing, Part 1 skills)

Part 1 of the C2 Proficiency Writing paper asks you to summarise and evaluate the key ideas of two texts. Practise the first half here: compress the writer’s argument without copying it.

Strategy · compress, don’t copy. Find the one sentence each paragraph exists to say. Then write it again with different words: nouns instead of clauses (*the persistence of these festivals*), and one linker for the turn in the argument (*Although purists…, the writer argues…*). Examiners penalise “lifting” whole phrases from the text.

The writer’s argument in 50–60 words, in your own words

The two key points you would keep if you only had 25 words

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Evaluation: one point you agree with and one you would challenge, with a reason for each

Two phrases from the text you would like to use yourself (and where)

Self-assessment

Circle: 1 Not yet · 2 Partly · 3 Mostly · 4 Fully

5 Listening: listen like an examiner

A short BBC video made for children. Understanding it will be easy, so listen like a C2 Proficiency examiner: the facts, but also who the video is for, what it is trying to do and how it says things. Watch it once, read the questions, then watch it again.

🎧 **Happy Diwali** · YouTube video: your teacher will play it for you (youtube.com/watch?v=kjIPGD_WcEY).

1. Who is the video mainly made for?
   a) tourists planning a trip to India **b)** children who are learning English
   c) adults who already know a lot about Diwali **d)** teachers of religious studies
2. What is the main purpose of the video?
   a) to compare Diwali with Christmas in detail **b)** to introduce the festival in a simple, positive way
   c) to sell tickets for a Diwali event **d)** to argue that Diwali has become too commercial
3. How long does Diwali last, according to the video?
   a) eight nights **b)** five days **c)** two weeks **d)** one night
4. Which groups does the video say celebrate Diwali?
   a) everyone in the UK **b)** Hindus and Muslims **c)** only Hindus in India **d)** Hindus, Sikhs and Jains
5. Why does the video mention Leicester?
   a) because it is the only UK city that celebrates it **b)** because Diwali started there
   c) to explain where the lamps are made **d)** to show that Diwali is also celebrated on a big scale in the UK
6. What do the lights stand for, according to the video?
   a) the number of days of the festival **b)** the start of winter
   c) good winning over evil, and light over darkness **d)** the wealth of each family

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7. You are rewriting “Diwali is a festival of lights. People light lamps.” for an adult documentary. Which version has the most natural C2 register?
   a) Known as the festival of lights, Diwali sees homes and streets lit with rows of small oil lamps.
   b) Diwali is a really, really nice festival with loads of lights.
   c) Diwali is a festival. It has lights. People light lamps.
   d) Lights are lit by people at Diwali, which is a festival of lights.
8. Which of these would an adult documentary about Diwali most likely add that this video leaves out?
   a) the name of the festival
   b) the different stories and meanings the festival has for each religion and region
   c) that Diwali is a happy time **d)** the fact that people light lamps

6 Real video: the ancient history of the winter solstice

A real documentary-style video at native speed (World History Encyclopedia). Watch it once for the argument, then answer: some questions test detail, others how confidently the presenter presents her claims. Compare it with the text in the Reading tab (“Why we light up the darkest days”).

🎧 **Ancient History of Winter Solstice Traditions and Sites** · YouTube video: your teacher will play it for you (youtube.com/watch?v=qX9NEUE6ed0).

1. What is the presenter’s opening claim?
   a) Only northern peoples celebrated midwinter.
   b) People were marking the winter solstice long before Christmas existed.
   c) The solstice is no longer celebrated anywhere. **d)** Christmas was invented to replace the solstice.
2. Which idea does she present as common to most solstice festivals?
   a) Giving thanks for the harvest **b)** Fasting before a feast **c)** Light overcoming darkness, and renewal
   d) Honouring the dead
3. What was socially unusual about Saturnalia in Rome?
   a) The usual hierarchy was turned upside down: masters ate with and even served their slaves.
   b) Shops stayed open all night. **c)** Everyone had to wear a toga.
   d) Only slaves were allowed to celebrate.
4. According to the video, why were large animals slaughtered at Yule?
   a) They would have been hard to feed through the winter, so the meat was shared out.
   b) It was a punishment for a bad harvest. **c)** Their skins were needed for winter clothes.
   d) They were sacrificed to the sun god.
5. The presenter explains that the “tide” in “Yuletide” means…
   a) the movement of the sea **b)** a period of time **c)** a gift exchanged at midwinter
   d) a religious ceremony
6. Why does she single out Newgrange in Ireland?
   a) It is the largest stone circle in Europe.
   b) It is older than Stonehenge, and its passage is lit by the solstice sunrise, which shows great precision.
   c) It is still used for solstice sacrifices. **d)** It is where Yule was first celebrated.

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7. She traces trees, wreaths and mistletoe to Yule, and “perhaps even” Santa Claus. What does “perhaps even” signal?

   a) She is less confident about this last link than about the others.

   b) She thinks Santa Claus is the most important link. **c)** She is quoting a historian she disagrees with.

   d) She is joking and does not believe any of the links.

8. Which is the fairest critical evaluation of the video? (Think of the Reading tab: festivals have always borrowed and adapted.)

   a) It is unreliable because it gives no dates. **b)** It only presents the Christian point of view.

   c) It deliberately avoids any connection with Christmas.

   d) It is informative, but it sometimes presents contested links between ancient festivals and Christmas as settled fact.

7 Grammar for emphasis: inversion and cleft sentences

Key word transformations (Reading and Use of English, Part 4): complete the second sentence so it means the same as the first, using 3–8 words including the word in CAPITALS. Small changes in spelling are not accepted, so be precise.

How it works

Negative inversion for emphasis: *Never have I seen… · Not only does it…, but… · Only when… did… · No sooner had… than… · At no time did… · Little did they know…*

Cleft sentences to focus on one part: *What I love about Diwali is the lamps. · It was in 1863 that Thanksgiving became official. · All I want is a quiet New Year.*

Exam tip: Part 4 usually tests two things at once (grammar + a fixed phrase). Count your words and check that the key word is unchanged.

1. I have never seen such a spectacular parade. NEVER → _____ such a spectacular parade.
2. The festival is beautiful and it is also free. ONLY → Not _____, but it is also free.
3. We realised how late it was only when the fireworks started. DID → Only when the fireworks started _____ how late it was.
4. As soon as the clock struck twelve, everyone started singing. SOONER → No _____ twelve than everyone started singing.
5. They had no idea that the party was for them. LITTLE → _____ that the party was for them.
6. I love the atmosphere of Sant Joan most. WHAT → _____ the atmosphere.
7. Lincoln made Thanksgiving a national holiday in 1863. IT → _____ Lincoln made Thanksgiving a national holiday.
8. You must not light fireworks indoors under any circumstances. CIRCUMSTANCES → Under _____ light fireworks indoors.
9. The only thing I want this New Year is some peace and quiet. ALL → _____ this New Year is some peace and quiet.
10. The organisers did not apologise at any point. TIME → At _____ apologise.

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8 Open cloze: The paradox of the festive season

Reading and Use of English, Part 2: one word in each gap, mostly grammar words (prepositions, linkers, pronouns, parts of fixed phrases). Read the whole paragraph first.

How it works

For a season supposedly devoted (1) ___ joy, December can be strangely exhausting. (2) ___ the endless lists, the crowded shops and the obligatory gatherings, many people reach January feeling (3) ___ though they need a holiday from their holidays. Psychologists point out that it is not the celebrations (4) ___ that wear us down, (5) ___ rather the pressure to enjoy them. (6) ___ more we expect to feel, the more we notice what we are not feeling. Perhaps the answer lies (7) ___ lowering our expectations, (8) ___ is easier said than done.

Tip: look at what comes after each gap as well as before it: (5) and (6) are parts of two-part structures.

1. (1) supposedly devoted _____ joy
2. (2) _____ the endless lists… (= because of all)
3. (3) feeling _____ though they need a holiday
4. (4) it is not the celebrations _____ that wear us down
5. (5) not the celebrations…, _____ rather the pressure
6. (6) _____ more we expect to feel, the more we notice…
7. (7) the answer lies _____ lowering our expectations
8. (8) …, _____ is easier said than done

9 Piece 1: an article (C2 Proficiency Writing, Part 2)

This text is the first piece of your final product. Write it as an exam answer: plan for five minutes, write, then check.

Your task

An international magazine for young people is running a series called *“A celebration that says more about us than we think”*. Write an **article** (280–320 words) about a celebration you know well. Describe it vividly for readers who have never experienced it, and argue what it reveals about the people who celebrate it today. Give your article a title.

Model (don’t copy it)

A different celebration, for the structure only. **The night the whole town stays awake** · Paragraph 1: a scene, not a definition (the hour before the first bonfire). · Paragraph 2: what actually happens, with two precise details a visitor would not expect. · Paragraph 3: the turn: what the night is “officially” about, and what it is really about now. · Paragraph 4: what that reveals (belonging, release, defiance of the dark), with one concession to the sceptic. · Closing line that echoes the opening scene.

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10 Speaking: plan a long turn (no recording)

The question

How important is it for a community to keep its traditional celebrations?

Ideas on the card: identity and belonging · tourism and money · celebrations that change or disappear

C2 Proficiency Speaking, Part 3: you get a question with some ideas on a card and speak alone for about two minutes. Here you only plan it.

🧭 **Strategy**

Step 1 · Dump, then choose (15 seconds). Write everything that comes to mind, including the obvious. Your first idea is usually everyone's first idea: keep it as a starting point, not as your main point.

Step 2 · Pick a line, not a list. Examiners reward a developed answer with a position. Choose two or three ideas that build on each other (for example: belonging → but tourism changes it → so the real question is who the celebration is for).

Step 3 · Plan the shape: opening position → idea 1 with an example → idea 2 that complicates it → a conclusion that goes slightly further than your opening. You do not have to use every idea on the card.

Your plan · Write notes, not full sentences: this is the thinking you would do in the exam's preparation time.

What comes to mind first? (everything, in 15 seconds)

identity, grandparents, Sant Joan, tourists, money…

Which two or three ideas are the strongest, and why? (one is allowed to be your first idea)

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Your order: opening position → idea 1 (example) → idea 2 → conclusion

Three phrases you will use to link or to buy time

What strikes me is… / That said,… / It's a question of…

A model plan

(read it only after you have written your plan)

Position: Important, but not for the reason people usually give.
Idea 1: Belonging: Sant Joan in my street, the one night neighbours who never speak share food. That is the real value.
Idea 2 (complicates it): When a celebration is kept "for tourists", it can survive in form and die in meaning (example: a parade staged for cameras).
Conclusion (goes further): So the question is not whether we keep them, but who they are for. A tradition worth keeping is one the community would still do with nobody watching.

Linking and buying time: *The obvious answer would be…, but… · What strikes me is… · Take…, for instance. · That said,… · Which brings me back to…*

Notice: the first idea (identity) is kept but sharpened; tourism is used to complicate it, not as a separate list item; the conclusion adds something new.

What would you change in your plan now? (one sentence)

🔁 How did it go?

What helped me most?

What do I need to review?

📚 Study guide: prepare for Checkpoint 1 and the final exam

How to study what you learn in this Learning Path, and practice that works like the checkpoint and looks like the exam. The answer key is at the end of each activity.

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How to study

🧠 Test yourself, don't reread

Close your notes and try to remember: write the words, say the rule, answer the questions. Then check. Rereading and highlighting feel useful, but you remember much less.

Retrieval practice · Roediger & Karpicke 2006; Dunlosky et al. 2013

📅 Spread it out

Three short sessions of 15 minutes on different days work better than one long session the day before.

Spacing · Cepeda et al. 2006

🔀 Mix it up

Practise similar things together so you learn to choose the right one for each sentence.

Interleaving · Rohrer & Taylor 2007

✅ Check and fix at once

Mark your answers with the key straight away and write each wrong answer again, correctly.

Feedback · Hattie & Timperley 2007

💬 Say why

For every answer, say the reason: "on, because it's a date." Explaining makes the rule stick.

Self-explanation · Dunlosky et al. 2013

😴 Sleep on it

Your brain stores what you learn while you sleep. A short self-test and a good night's sleep beat studying late the night before.

Sleep and memory · Diekelmann & Born 2010

My plan

1. **Today** · Close this page and write from memory: five celebration words and two customs with on / in / at. Then check.
2. **In 2–3 days** · Do "Practise for Checkpoint 1" below. Look at the key and write again what you got wrong.
3. **Before Checkpoint 1** · Go over the flashcards: only the ones you still miss.
4. **The week before the exam** · Do the exam-style practice in every Learning Path, then the Sample exam. Repeat only the parts you failed.

What comes up

Checkpoint 1 (LS1 and Learning Paths 1 and 2): short gaps, collocations and word formation, one question at a time, about 45 seconds each, no going back and no notes. You do it once, and you must stay on the page: if you leave it, it is sent. It opens the next Learning Path.
Final exam: the C2 version: listening for attitude and implication, a long reading, vocabulary (multiple-choice cloze and word formation), grammar (open cloze and key word transformations) and a formal letter.

Practise for Checkpoint 1

One question at a time · 45 s

It works like the real checkpoint: 10 questions, one at a time, about 45 seconds each, with no going back and no notes. This is only practice: nothing is sent, you can repeat it, and at the end you see your answers and the key.

On paper: cover the questions and uncover them one at a time, about 45 seconds each, with no going back.

1. Sant Joan is deeply _____ in Catalan culture.
2. The town holds a _____ (COMMEMORATE) service every November.

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3. We put our differences to one _____ for Christmas dinner.
4. Not _____ do we eat together, but we also sing.
5. Diwali is celebrated _____ (WORLD) by Hindus, Sikhs and Jains.
6. The custom has been handed _____ from generation to generation.
7. The square was _____ with people for the fireworks.
8. Only after midnight _____ the presents opened.
9. Lunar New Year marks the _____ of spring.
10. The festive _____ seems to start earlier every year.

Like the exam: Vocabulary 1 point · gaps 2 points

Choose the right word, or type it.

1. The procession is the ___ of the whole festival. [1 point]
a) spotlight **b)** highlight **c)** limelight **d)** headlight

2. Families ___ their ancestors with offerings of food. [1 point]
a) regard **b)** remind **c)** reward **d)** honour

3. The _____ (SIGNIFY) of the lamps is light over darkness. [2 points]

4. The whole neighbourhood took _____ in the celebrations. [2 points]

Like the exam: Grammar 1 point · gaps 2 points

Choose the right form, or type it.

1. We had barely arrived when the fireworks started. BARELY → _____ when the fireworks started. [2 points]

2. People say the custom is very old. SAID → The custom _____ very old. [2 points]

3. Open cloze: _____ it not for my grandmother, we would have forgotten the recipe. [2 points]

4. Open cloze: The more we celebrate together, _____ closer we feel. [2 points]

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📚 Study guide: answer key

Look at them only when you have finished each activity.

Practise for Checkpoint 1

1. **rooted** · deeply rooted in.
2. **commemorative** · commemorate → commemorative.
3. **side** · put something to one side.
4. **only** · Not only do we… but also…
5. **worldwide** · world → worldwide.
6. **down** · hand down.
7. **packed** · packed with people.
8. **are** · Only after… + inversion (passive).
9. **beginning** · mark the beginning of.
10. **season** · the festive season.

Like the exam: Vocabulary

1. **highlight** · the highlight = the best part.
2. **honour** · honour the ancestors.
3. **significance** · signify → significance.
4. **part** · take part in.

Like the exam: Grammar

1. **barely had we arrived** · Barely had we… when…
2. **is said to be** · is said to + infinitive.
3. **were** · Were it not for… (inverted conditional).
4. **the** · The more…, the…

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